



I normally buy a netbook and replace the disk with a solid-state drive. The original disk is used as an external USB drive. The configuration is a 28cm screen, 2GB RAM and the device weighs just over a kilo.

This time I came across a Chromebook with a 35.5cm display and 4GB RAM. Although the disk is a mere 32GB, there were rumours of Linux apps being made available on Chromebooks. The weight is just a kilogram and the battery lasts up to ten hours. This seemed like a good option to try out.

Although the hardware is the same as that of a laptop, the firmware needs to be replaced if you want to install Linux natively. The alternate firmware should be available for your Chromebook. I did not consider that option.

Linux Apps on ChromeOS

In this series of articles, the author, who likes to explore different software and hardware devices, outlines his experiences with Linux apps on a Chromebook.

I used Crouton to install Ubuntu on the Chromebook. The major disadvantage is that Ubuntu runs in a virtual machine. The ChromeOS and Linux environments are separate. Switching between the two is clumsy.

Linux apps on ChromeOS

With ChromeOS 70, Linux apps are available on the Chromebook I have. One needs to enable Linux apps. Chrome OS downloads and installs the Linux container and a Linux terminal app. You can now use the Debian *apt-get* command to install whatever Linux apps you may need.

A bare minimum explanation of what the Linux container installation involves is as follows – from the documentation at <https://goo.gl/T9MFE3>:

- Crostini is the umbrella term for making Linux application support easy-to-use and integrate well with Chrome OS. It largely focuses on getting you a terminal with a

container, with easy access to install whatever developer-focused tools you might want.

- Terminal is a VM image with a stripped-down Chrome OS Linux kernel and userland tools. Its only goal is to boot up as quickly as possible and start running containers. Many of the programs/tools are customised here.

I needed LibreOffice, GNUMCash and a few solitaire games. For financial transactions, I am more comfortable with Firefox. The repository contains *firefox-esr*; so I installed that as well.

Each Linux app runs in a window in the Chrome OS environment. So, it is easy to switch between Chrome and Linux applications. It reminded me of running remote Linux applications using the `$ ssh -X user@host application-command`.

The Linux container is private for a Chrome user. If you have multiple users on Chromebook, each one will need to have his or her own Linux environment.

Usage

Powering on a Chromebook is very fast. Using a Linux app is just like using a ChromeOS app. The common ones may be pinned to the shelf (taskbar). The first Linux app you start takes a while as it has to start the Linux container/VM image and then the application. Text copy/paste works across the Chrome and Linux app windows as well. More data types are likely to be supported across the environments. The Chrome file manager lets you see the files in the Linux virtual machine as well, and you may copy/move files.

